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January 28, 2026

To: Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award Program
UCLA Teaching and Learning Center

From: Gregory S. Okin
okin@ucla.edu

Re: Michelle De Luna

Dear Committee,

With great enthusiasm, I write this departmental letter to support the nomination of Michelle De Luna for the UCLA Distinguished Teaching Assistant Award. Michelle is in the final year of the PhD program. She has taught hundreds of Geography and non-Geography students via eight lower-division and upper-division geography classes. She won the departmental Outstanding TA Award in 2025, a highly competitive honor in a department that is known for its strong commitment to and high achievements in teaching.

Student-centeredness is a hallmark of Michelle's teaching. She enables student success by empowering students as partners and "principal actors" in their learning process. Among the tools she developed are a survey at the beginning of a class and another survey after the midterm exam, creatively establishing a "friendly dialogue" with students and using their feedback to adjust her teaching. For example, based on student feedback, Michelle developed group activities that promote peer learning when students play the role of both learners and teachers. As a result, the students' voices are heard, their ideas are recognized, and they contribute to a community learning experience.

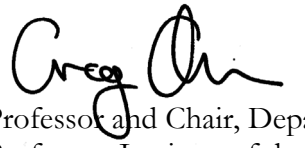
Another effective strategy of Michelle's is to earn the students' trust by always being there to help. Student comments highlight Michelle as "extremely interactive," "extremely helpful," and "very responsive." She is committed "to inspire and encourage," and she is "very enthusiastic every day in lab." She "encouraged people to ask for help," "cares very much about students," ensures that "everyone could be engaged," has "a strong desire to help the students succeed," "commits to our learning," and "prioritized our learning." Michelle goes "above and beyond to help" students by for example shifting her office hours and meeting students beyond office hours in order to reach all students.

Finally, Michelle respects and acknowledges students' struggles, and by doing so she not only helps them learn but builds their confidence. This is rooted in her own appreciation for educational opportunities, as a child of immigrant parents, and in her passion for inclusive teaching. In addition to being "good at explaining concepts" and helping students "greatly in mastering [this] complex tool" of Geographic Information Systems (GIS), she is not afraid to allow them to see her as an equal and sympathetic partner in their learning journey. For example, she mentored a student who feared GIS by delving into each

assignment step by step as well as sharing with the student her own struggles in the past. In this way, the student found the class "safe and very comfortable" and felt that "I can do scary things and succeed."

In conclusion, Michelle is an extremely thoughtful and effective TA in engaging students as partners to enable their success, through innovative tools that invite students' voices and input, establishing herself as a trusted partner, and mentoring students by sharing her own struggles. This partnership, inclusive and student-centered approach has made Michelle an outstanding and impactful TA, who is most deserving of the UCLA Distinguished TA Award.

Sincerely,



Professor and Chair, Department of Geography
Professor, Institute of the Environment and Sustainability

Enabling Student Success Through Partnership: Testimony from a UCLA Teaching Assistant

My commitment to education is a reflection of the scarce educational opportunities that were available to my ancestors in the very recent past. I am reminded of the lost dreams and continued sacrifice of many immigrant parents - including my own - who have given everything for their American children, and it is this everpresent reminder that serves to fuel my daily appreciation for learning, not only as a graduate student but also as a teaching assistant (TA) who partners with students to ensure access to a quality university experience.

The efficacy of my work as an educator can be understood by considering my subscription to evidence-based teaching pedagogy. Through my active participation in the various workshops hosted by UCLA's Teaching and Learning Center (TLC), I have adopted effective strategies that improve classroom dynamics by creating a safe and inclusive learning environment. One particular strategy that strongly reflects my teaching approach utilizes student feedback to adapt instruction based on perceived strengths and weaknesses. At the beginning of each quarter, for example, I prepare a nongraded survey where students are encouraged to introduce themselves and share their expectations for the following weeks (**see DeLuna_artifact_1**). This survey establishes a friendly dialogue with students and allows me as their course facilitator to gauge their preferred direction for instruction. After the midterm exam, a subsequent survey is administered to inquire about student morale and, more importantly, to assess the structure of lab sections (**see DeLuna_artifact_2**). Here we stop to question whether the existing class structure is enhancing student learning or if specific changes are necessary.

The feedback strategy mentioned above ensures that students remain principal actors in their learning experience, and it encourages them to see me as an equal partner supporting their educational goals. In essence, it ensures student success through partnership. In the past, student feedback has brought to my attention the utility of group activities and the need for additional, more accessible review sessions that demystify difficult concepts. Although the order of material covered in my lab sections often aligns with course deadlines and therefore remains temporally fixed in the lab syllabus (**see DeLuna_artifact_3**), student feedback has prompted changes in the general design of remaining lab sections. For instance, in the past, I have combined passive (i.e. lecture-style) and active (i.e. group work) teaching methods to assist our review of key course concepts, which formed the basis of homework assignments that students were motivated to complete in lab. I've also supplemented labs with visual aids and real-world occurrences to illustrate to students the development of certain processes in the physical world (**see DeLuna_artifact_4**). As noted by one student, adaptations to the structural design of lab ultimately enabled me as course facilitator to "work with [students] directly on assignments or concepts we had gone over in lecture and [keep] discussion times down to an efficient level so everyone could be engaged." Another student described lab sections to be "really helpful and

definitely critical to doing well in the course," with presentations that were "well prepared" and slides that were "super easy to understand" (**see DeLuna_artifact_5**).

Results from both in-class surveys and Student Experiences of Teaching (SET) suggest students view me as a person with strong knowledge of course material (median = 9*) and acknowledge my concern for student learning, which is nearly always classified as "high" or "very high or always." Survey statistics also indicate that students feel welcome in seeking help in and outside the classroom (median = 9*), which confirms to me the value of treating the university learning experience as a partnership between educator and student.

Last year, my efforts as a TA were recognized by my home department and I was honoured with the "Outstanding Geography TA Award." While it is a distinction I carry with great pride, the most valuable recognition I have received during my time at UCLA are the various expressions of support and confidence from students at the end of the quarter. A simple "thank you for being so supportive throughout the quarter" (Frank Han, GEOG 119) or "I really appreciate the care you shared with me" (Gicela Galvez, GEOG 7) are enough to prove to me that I am exactly what I was meant to be: an educational mentor and partner.

*Values are based on a scale ranging from 1 (very low or never) to 9 (very high or always).

Teaching philosophy: My teaching is rooted in the belief that students learn best when they are able to see that "everything is related to everything else" across space and time (Tobler 1970). As a geographer, I promote an interdisciplinary learning experience that encourages students to not only view but also think critically - and engage with - our interconnected world. My main objective as an educator, then, is to develop students who value knowledge and feel confident in pursuing a wide-range of professions, including those which require technical competency. This is accomplished by familiarizing myself with the personal experiences and academic needs of students in order to adequately prepare them to fulfill their professional ambitions.

Teaching experience: As a departmental teaching assistant (TA), I have worked with hundreds of undergraduate students across both the physical and human branches of geography; I have also instructed non-majors enrolled in general education courses. Assisting a diverse student population has been a rewarding experience since it has taught me to successfully transition from discussions on the history of the environmental justice movement to discussions that seek to quantitatively derive Earth's energy balance. It has also shown me the value of employing a universal teaching approach that prioritizes the acquisition of knowledge through the use of various geospatial tools, which are free (i.e. open access) and publicly available.

I use a variety of pedagogical approaches to facilitate student learning in the classroom. For example, when examining the processes that define our physical environment, I employ an integrative approach that utilizes real-world events to augment student comprehension. A lecture on midlatitude cyclones, or large storms that rotate rapidly and move energy (and moisture) from relatively warm to cold parts of the world, is typically followed by a lab section where students use interactive weather maps (e.g. Zoom Earth) to locate active storms across the Northern Hemisphere. Such an approach is particularly useful when trying to exemplify the applicability of course material, as is the case when geography and non-geography students alike can connect the intense rain event developing outside to a fast-approaching cyclone!

My teaching strives to enhance the integrative process by implementing group exercises that promote peer learning. During weekly labs, students are channeled into small groups and assigned a common goal, such as identifying a recurring theme in the literature, solving a weekly homework question, or executing a new software task. This dynamic encourages social interaction and allows participants to assume the roles of both learner and teacher. In my experience, group activities also provide students with a strong sense of purpose, thereby increasing the probability of achieving their immediate goal and ultimately contributing to their overall satisfaction with the educational experience provided at UCLA.

Mentorship: Above all, I try to as a teacher provide mentorship opportunities to individual students who face specific academic challenges and require additional support.

During my time as a TA for an introductory Geographic Information Systems (GIS) course, I was assigned a student who expressed a desperate need to pass the course - the class was part of their major coursework and graduation was right around the corner. Despite their motivation, my student expressed a debilitating sense of frustration given the technical nature of the course, which relied on complex mapping software to process data and produce digital maps. "I was always fearful about GIS because I am not tech savvy," they confessed to me in an email after the end of the quarter. "In fact, I tried taking [the course] last quarter and dropped it after the second week because I was too overwhelmed and felt alone in the class." Over the span of ten

weeks, my student and I met during office hours to clarify the objective of weekly assignments and to review the purpose of certain mapping functions. We repeated function-related tasks step by step until my student could successfully replicate the task on their own. During the ten-week period, I was also able to share with my student the overwhelming troubles I had endured years before as a former participant in the class - a class I was now (ironically) teaching.

Through this experience, I was able to gain my student's trust and build their confidence in exploring GIS software. As a result, they learned to produce high-quality maps and passed the course with high marks. "Being a part of your lab section this quarter felt safe and very comfortable," they concluded. "It also proved to me that I can do scary things and succeed."

Future experiences: My experience as a TA has been gratifying and I am highly motivated to pursue a tenure-track position at an institution of higher education with an existing geography program. I aim to design courses that equip students with the analytical and technical skills required to examine various social and physical phenomena across space and time, and I would be especially well-prepared to assist with introductory-level courses in physical geography and GIS. My research interest in the cryosphere - the frozen parts of the planet - could also lend itself to the development of an upper-division course with a focus on polar climatology, or the average climatic conditions of the poles. A course of this nature could encourage students to employ GIS technologies to address an environmental issue currently affecting the Arctic and/or Antarctic regions.

In addition to leading individual courses, I am excited by the possibility of mentoring students through their academic journey - an experience I have benefited from enormously as a student at UCLA. In particular, I look forward to preparing students for careers in research, which could lead to positions in both academia and industry and thereby contribute to the advancement of scientific knowledge.

GEOG 1: Preliminary Survey

This survey seeks to understand student interest in physical geography.

1. What is your current student status (year) at UCLA?

   Mark only one oval.

   - ◯ Freshman (1st)
   - ◯ Sophomore (2nd)
   - ◯ Junior (3rd)
   - ◯ Senior (4th)
   - ◯ Other

2. Why did you enroll in GEOG 1? Select the answer that best describes your choice.

   Mark only one oval.

   - ◯ It seemed like an interesting course.
   - ◯ It is a major/minor requirement for my degree.
   - ◯ It is a GE requirement (science option).
   - ◯ Other: _____

3. Have you taken a physical geography course before?

   Mark only one oval.

   - ◯ Yes
   - ◯ No

4. Based on your experience so far, how challenging is the course material for you?

Mark only one oval.

- ◯ Not challenging at all
- ◯ Adequate
- ◯ Somewhat challening
- ◯ Very challenging

5. How do you feel about the speed with which course material is presented during lectures?

Mark only one oval.

- ◯ Too slow
- ◯ Adequate
- ◯ Too fast

6. Is there anything you would like me to know about you or your preferred learning style?

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GEOG 1: Mid-Quarter Assessment

This is a brief assessment of your experience with GEOG 1 and the midterm exam. All responses are anonymous and confidential.

1. How do you feel about your status in the course after taking the midterm exam?

   Mark only one oval.

   - ◯ Highly content
   - ◯ Content
   - ◯ Neutral
   - ◯ Discontent
   - ◯ Highly discontent/concerned

2. Did you encounter a specific issue on the midterm exam?

   Mark only one oval.

   - ◯ Yes
   - ◯ No

3. If you encountered an issue on the exam, please elaborate here:

   _____

4. Do you feel like attending lecture was useful in preparing for the midterm exam?

   Mark only one oval.

   - ◯ Yes
   - ◯ No
   - ◯ Other: _____

5. Do you feel like the homework assignments were helpful in preparing you for the midterm exam?

   Mark only one oval.

   - ◯ Yes
   - ◯ No
   - ◯ Other: _____

6. Do you feel like attending your lab section was useful in preparing you for the midterm exam?

   Mark only one oval.

   - ◯ Yes
   - ◯ No
   - ◯ Other: _____

7. One thing I like about my lab section is...

   _____

8. One thing I would like my lab section to work on is...

   _____

This content is neither created nor endorsed by Google.

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Introduction to Physical Geography (GEOG 1) Lab

Lab 1C: Tuesdays 2:00-3:00pm | Bunche 1221B
Lab 1D: Tuesdays 4:00-5:00pm | Bunche 1221B

Teaching Assistant (TA): Michelle De Luna
Email: mideluna@g.ucla.edu
Office Hours: Tuesdays 3:00-4:00pm + Thursdays 12:30-1:30pm | Bunche 1221B

Welcome to GEOG 1! In this course, we will study the different components that make up our physical environment: the atmosphere, biosphere, cryosphere, hydrosphere, and lithosphere. Lab sections are designed to complement lecture material and will achieve the following objectives:

1. Promote knowledge retention by expanding on concepts introduced in lecture
2. Ensure student success by providing guided homework assistance
3. Prepare students for course exams by introducing effective study strategies

Lab Evaluation: Participation in lab sections is a weighted component of this course (12%). Students receive points (1.5% of total grade) for each lab section they attend.

Absence Policy: One (1) unexcused absence is allowed at no cost to the student's grade. One (1) unexcused absence is also allowed and permits students to make up lost participation points by completing a written assignment. Students must provide proper documentation (e.g. a signed medical note, athletic travel letter, etc.) to receive a make-up assignment, which must be emailed to me one (1) week from receipt.

Office Hours: I am available to provide individual guidance on course material and homework assignments during office hours. Please take advantage of this learning opportunity, which is intentionally set up before or after your lab section to maximize student participation. Note also that any grade disputes should be presented in office hours.

Weekly Schedule

Week 2:	Preliminary survey + Introductions + Homework 1 (seasons, radiative equilibrium)
Week 3:	Homework 1 (greenhouse gases, sensible + latent heat flux, Coriolis)
Week 4:	Homework 2 (convergence + subsidence, Hadley circulation)
Week 5:	Homework 2 (Clausius-Clapeyron relation, ocean currents) + Midterm Review
Week 6:	Homework 3 (upwelling, continental drift, seafloor spreading)
Week 7:	Homework 3 (hydrologic cycle)
Week 8:	Homework 4 (evapotranspiration, snow water equivalent)
Week 9:	Homework 4 (erosion, Milankovitch cycles)
Week 10:	Final survey + Exam Review | Please email me questions/topics you would like to review!

GEOG 1:
Intro to Physical Geography

Lab Sections C and D



TA: Michelle De Luna

Tuesdays 2:00-3:00pm | Bunche 1221B

Tuesdays 4:00-5:00pm | Bunche 1221B

Weekly Reminders

- **Office Hours** - I will email you a link for virtual office hours.
- **Homework Assignment #4** - Due this **Sunday, December 3rd by 11:59pm**! I will have grades posted shortly thereafter so you can use HW to study for your final exam.
- **Final Exam** - Your final is scheduled for **Monday, December 11th @ 8:00am**.
- **Instructor Evaluations** - Please take the time to complete instructor evaluations for your professors and TAs.

Assignment 4

1) In the western United States, does severe forest fire tend to increase or decrease streamflow (1 point)? What are the two main reasons hypothesized to cause this effect (4 points)? **5 points total**

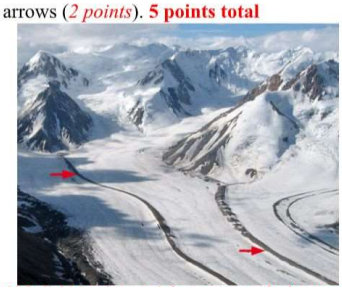


What happens to vegetation after a fire? How does this change in vegetation affect evapotranspiration (ET)?

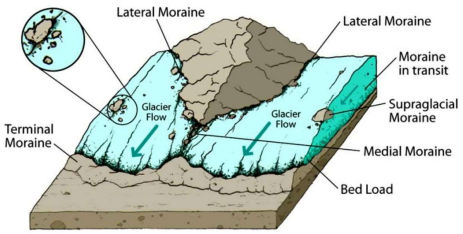
What happens to soil during a fire? How does this affect the soil's relationship with water?

Source: National Parks Service

2) The picture below is of the Kaskawulsh Glacier in Yukon, Canada. What is the name of the type of feature that the red arrows are pointing to in the middle of the glacier (*1 point*) and how are these features formed (*2 points*)? In your answer please also define the term lateral moraine and how lateral moraines relate to the feature with the red arrows (*2 points*). **5 points total**



Moraine: a geographic feature made up of material (e.g. rock, debris) that was eroded and left behind by a glacier.



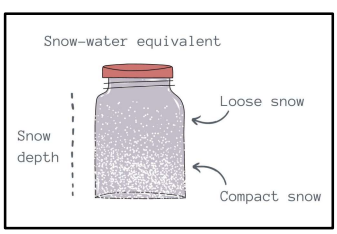
Source: National Geographic

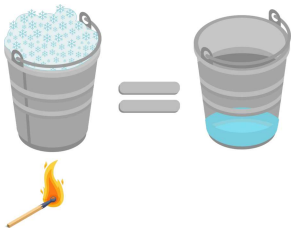
Lateral Moraine: "to the side," an accumulation of rock/debris that forms to the side of a glacier.

Medial Moraine: "in the middle," an accumulation of rock/debris that forms when two glaciers come together.

3) Please explain what the term snow water equivalent means (*1 point*) and why this variable is more meaningful for water resources than snow depth (*2 points*)? **3 points total**

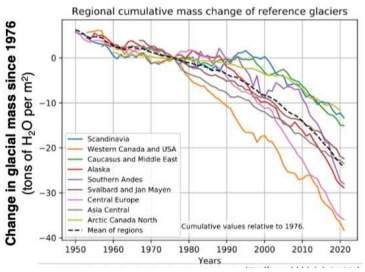
Snow Water Equivalent (SWE): the amount of liquid water that would result if we melted a snowpack.

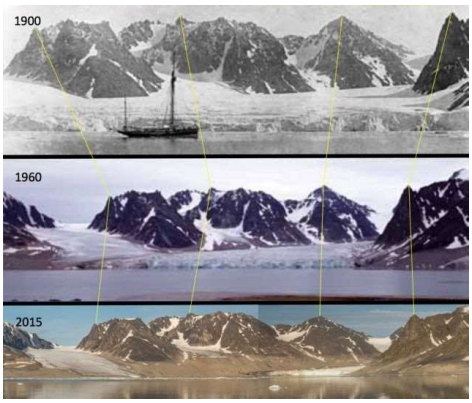




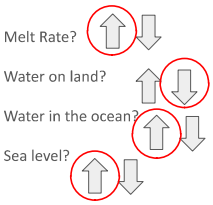
Source: USGS

4) The figure below shows the average change in glacier mass per unit area for various mountainous regions around the world. Why are the globe's mountain glaciers shrinking (*2 points*)? How does glacial melt affect the amount of water stored on the continents (increase or decrease) (*1 point*)? What are the factors in the continental water budget equation that must change in order to restore equilibrium when glaciers melt (*1 point*)? What is the effect on global sea level (*1 point*)?





Source: Columbia climate School



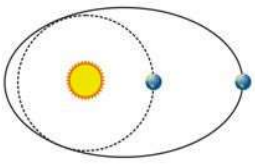
What about runoff?

5) Why might drought actually cause fire risk to reduce in a desert area? **4 points total**



6) For the past 3 million years the earth has experienced glacial-interglacial cycles at regular intervals that coincide with the Milankovitch Cycles. Please briefly describe the three Milankovitch Cycles and their timescales (*3 points*). What is the leading theory for the reason that the timing glacial-interglacial cycles are connected to these Milankovitch Cycles (*2 points*). **5 points total**

Milankovitch Cycles



Eccentricity

~100,000 yrs

A change in the shape of Earth's orbit



Obliquity

~41,000 yrs

The tilt of Earth's axis



Precession

~25,000 yrs

The wobble of Earth, which can affect the direction of Earth's tilt

GEOG 1 | Introduction to Physical Geography

- She was the best TA and she would be very interactive and would love to answer questions making it easy for me to ask for help when I struggled with certain concepts. Her slides were super easy to understand and she would be extremely interactive with students, which was amazing.
- The strength of the teaching assistant was that she was very prepared to help students and often encouraged people to ask for help. She was always well prepared with presentations and did an excellent job of explaining the material. The weakness of the teaching assistant was the discussions went by quickly.
- Our TA walked us through everything we needed, and always went above and beyond to help us with anything we were struggling with. Sections were extremely helpful and supplemented my learning from lectures.
- Michelle is an amazing TA! She cares very much about her students and takes time to explain confusing concepts with care. She is very helpful during office hours and very responsive to emails. The discussion sections were really efficient, helpful, and definitely critical to doing well in the course. One thing I noted in the course was that the grading for the homework assignments were a bit harsher than I anticipated, but she was great at explaining how to improve.
- TA was realistic and focused on how to make students successful in the course. What was so great about this TA was that she did not try to busy us with tasks that were not relevant to use learning the material. She worked with us directly on assignments or concepts we had gone over in lecture and kept discussion times down to an efficient level so everyone could be engaged. I have no negative feedback to give.
- Michelle is an amazing TA. I went to her multiple times with specific questions and left each time with a good understanding of the topic and feeling confident with the material. In discussion sections Michelle had perfect pace with going over lecture material and explained it in new ways than the professor so that we understood it even more than before.
- She works really well with students and commits to our learning. She uses real life examples to relate to our current topic to better understand. Best T.A. I have ever had
- TA is good at explaining concepts from another perspective or with memorable examples that helped in understanding. Is able to guide us to the correct direction on homework assignments. Is able to engage students through group discussions and QnAs.

- The TA was very knowledgeable on the course material and students felt very comfortable approaching the TA with any questions. The TA showed to be a very valuable resource to students and enhanced student learning.
- I loved my TA. She was very sweet and knew everyone by name. She prioritized our learning and getting 100% on our homework answer. I hope my future TAs are like her.
- The teaching assistant was great at ensuring that students left the discussion with confusion about lecture material cleared up. The teaching assistant also demonstrated a strong desire to help the students succeed and discover a passion for the course content.

GEOG 7 | Introduction to Geographic Information Systems (GIS)

- I have great respect for Michelle's teaching methods, exceptional communication skills, and her remarkable talent to inspire and encourage us whenever we encounter challenges with the QGIS software. Her approach is truly admirable and has helped us greatly in mastering this complex tool.
- I really enjoyed this TA. She was very knowledgeable and acknowledged our struggles. The grading could be better. But she was very enthusiastic every day in lab. She was very well spoken and offered great insight into the expectations of assignments. Overall, very good.
- Michelle is a great TA who emphasizes professional development and mastery of cartography. At times this could be frustrating as it is an intro course and the grading could feel unfair (I got 10% off an assignment because I accidentally capitalized the letter K in "kiwi"), but I really don't think that this was her fault as she was just following instructions. Also, it forced me to pay extra attention to detail and continues to push me past just "good." Additionally, her commitment to her students is so amazing. She changed her office hours around so that more students could attend, and when I had a class during office hours still, she stayed a bit longer to help me with my map. Overall I appreciate this class and her help.

GEOG 119 | Global Climatology and Climate Change

- Michelle is very nice and she works really hard to grade students' assignments. Sometimes she put comments and highlights the part where students got points off, and it helps me realize how I did on the assignment and prevent make the same mistake in the future exams.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name Krystal Phillips

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)
Michelle De Luna was my TA for Geog 119 fall quarter 25.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Going to her office hours every week helped challenged me in my learning. We went over topics that were in lecture and she made a safe place for learning, she always made me feel welcome to ask any questions. Being a transfer I was scared but Michelle made my transition smooth and not as scary as I thought it was going to be. Seeing another women in the male dominant field that I wish to pursue inspires me in so many ways, to always keep going and to you belong in these places.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

She fostered a welcoming environment that we could ask any questions about the concepts, and even if I was stuck on a certain concept we would not move on to the next thing until she made sure I understood it.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Michelle is a very smart and inspiring person. She deserves this award because you can tell she really cares about her students and is passionate about the topics she teaches.

Distinguished Teaching Assistant — Letter of Recommendation

This award celebrates Teaching Assistants who demonstrate a pattern of effective teaching that incorporates current best practices (e.g., student-centered learning, active learning, inclusive teaching), aims to inspire and challenge students, and supports the success of all students.

Name: Frank Han

Briefly describe how you know the nominee. (50 words max)

I worked with Michelle De Luna as a student in her GEOG 119: Global Climatology and Climate Change course. When I struggled to understand several core concepts, I regularly attended her office hours, where she provided guidance and support that significantly improved my understanding of the material.

In a few sentences, describe a few ways in which the nominee inspired or challenged you or other students in the class. (200 words max)

Michelle consistently challenged students to think critically rather than simply providing direct answers. Instead of making concepts easier by giving solutions, she asked thoughtful questions that guided us to reason through problems ourselves. This approach helped me develop stronger analytical and problem-solving skills, especially when dealing with complex climate and atmospheric processes.

She also inspired me through her own attitude toward learning. During one conversation, she shared that she considers herself a lifelong learner and was actively taking undergraduate courses in the Atmospheric and Oceanic Sciences department at the same time she was teaching. When I mentioned my interest in understanding the different layers of the atmosphere, she encouraged me to explore research opportunities in the Earth and Planetary Sciences department. That suggestion had a lasting impact on me and motivated me to pursue deeper, interdisciplinary learning beyond the course requirements.

Describe one or two things that the nominee did that you thought were particularly beneficial for your (or other students') learning or understanding of concepts. (200 words max)

One of the most beneficial things Michelle did for students was organizing review sessions before both the midterm and final exams. These sessions were not required as part of her role as a teaching assistant, yet she still dedicated significant time and energy to preparing and leading them. The review sessions were well structured, interactive, and focused on helping students truly understand the material rather than memorizing answers.

By voluntarily holding these sessions, Michelle demonstrated an exceptional level of dedication to student learning. Managing large groups of students, answering questions, and explaining difficult concepts clearly requires both preparation and patience. Her willingness to go beyond her required responsibilities made a meaningful difference in my learning experience and helped many students feel more confident and supported throughout the course.

Please share any additional reasons why you believe the nominee is an outstanding candidate for this award. (100 words max)

Michelle is an outstanding candidate for this award because she genuinely inspires students to learn more deeply while making the learning process engaging and meaningful. She consistently went above and beyond her required duties, sacrificing her own time and energy to support students. Her dedication, passion for teaching, and commitment to student success reflect both strong character and exceptional teaching ability. I strongly believe her efforts deserve recognition and that her impact on students should be celebrated through this award.

UNIVERSITY OF CALIFORNIA, LOS ANGELES UCLA

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A. Park Williams
DEPARTMENT OF GEOGRAPHY
1255 BUNCHE HALL
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LOS ANGELES, CALIFORNIA 90095-1524

February 2, 2026

Dear Selection Committee,

I offer my strongest support for Michelle De Luna's nomination for the 2026 UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award for her outstanding work as a Teaching Assistant. Among the seven courses for which Michelle has served as TA, three have been for me, specifically by my request the last two times. Based on my excellent experiences working with Michelle, I successfully nominated her for our department's TA award last year and am delighted to now support her for this university-wide honor.

The effort Michelle puts into her TA role is on par with the best I have seen in 27 years in academia. I give TAs freedom to structure discussion sections; most use this time for informal Q&A. Michelle instead designs full lesson plans, creates her own lecture materials, and builds interactive learning activities. She routinely spends over 10 hours per week preparing, often extending beyond what is covered in lecture. She does this out of genuine care for her students and a clear understanding that teaching deeply is essential to mastering the material herself.

Michelle is also exceptional at connecting with individual students. Her office hours are unusually well attended, often drawing more than 10 students at a time. She strategically chooses convenient times and locations and actively encourages attendance. Rather than treating office hours as unwanted obligations, she welcomes student engagement, and students return because they see the value. Despite being responsible for 60–80 students in my courses, she learns most of their names and tracks their progress so closely that when I ask about particular students, she almost always knows exactly who they are and how they are doing.

Michelle's thoughtfulness about teaching is uniquely mature. She understands the importance of enforcing grading policies consistently so that students experience a fair and predictable system, and she views this consistency as part of helping them grow into responsible adults. At the same time, she shows appropriate compassion, and in one extraordinary case she gathered all the relevant information to persuade me that an exception to the grading policy was warranted.

Michelle's commitment to learning over popularity is also evident in her teaching evaluations, which she has shared with me. The vast majority of comments are positive, emphasizing her hard work, clarity, passion, and effectiveness. A minority of students complain about her rigorous and meticulous grading, including deductions for grammar and spelling. I view this as a strength. Michelle takes seriously the university's mission to prepare capable, confident, lifelong learners and understands that rigor and high standards are essential to that mission.

Finally, Michelle is extremely dependable and a clear communicator. She attends lectures even when not required, returns grades on time (or early when it will benefit students), and sets a

professional example that positively influences other TAs. I strongly support recognizing Michelle's exceptional dedication and effectiveness with a UCLA Distinguished Teaching Award, thereby highlighting to other graduate students and instructors what excellence in teaching looks like. Please do not hesitate to contact me with questions.

Sincerely,



Park Williams
Professor
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